A FIRM PRESENCE

Most MOTN respondents approve of the Modi government's overall foreign policy and are satisfied with its handling of the diplomatic row with Canada and the boycott of the Maldives as a tourist destination

By **PRADIP R. SAGAR**



IN the past six months, India's foreign policy has successfully navigated the twists and turns of modern geopolitics. New Delhi showed its diplomatic mettle by hosting the G20 summit and emerging as a credible voice of the Global South, while continuing to strike a balance between its 'principles' and 'interests' on sharply divisive global issues like the Israel-Hamas conflict and the Russia-Ukraine war. Diplomatic skills came again to the fore when India managed to reduce the death sentence of eight former Indian naval personnel at a Qatari court. Yet, there were tough challenges too. Amidst the ever-growing warmth in India-US ties—crowned by Prime Minister Narendra Modi's 2023 visit—came a discordant note: in November, Washington shared concerns that New Delhi was involved in a conspiracy to eliminate Khalistani terrorist Gurpatwant Singh Pannun, a US national. However, both India and the US are cooperating on the matter. Before that, in September 2023, India's relations with Canada hit rock bottom when Canadian prime minister Justin Trudeau levelled allegations against India about having a role in the killing of Canadian citizen Hardeep Singh Nijjar, designated a Khalistani terrorist by India. Casting their eyes over this eventful period, 46 per cent of the respondents of the INDIA TODAY-CVoter Mood of the Nation survey applauded PM Modi government's foreign policy as 'excellent', a drop from the over 48 per cent in August and the over 51 per cent in January 2023. Another 24 per cent of the respondents rated India's foreign policy performance as 'good' compared to 21.9 per cent in August.

India rejected Trudeau's allegations in the Canadian House of Commons as being 'absurd', leading to a sharp deterioration in bilateral ties. Subsequently, both nations expelled each other's diplomats and issued travel advisories. India temporarily halted visa services to Canadians. Nearly 47 per cent of MOTN respondents claimed that New Delhi handled this vexed issue well. Only 10 per cent felt India overreacted, and 18 per cent said India should have

57

PER CENT

OF THE RESPONDENTS FEEL THAT NEW DELHI'S TIES WITH ITS NEIGHBOURS HAVE DETERIORATED IN RECENT TIMES